

Tree acrobat

The red squirrel's long, bushy tail helps it balance as it leaps from tree to tree. It may also flip its tail to warn others of danger. The squirrel has long, strong back legs and hooked claws, which help it grip tree bark.

Eurasian red squirrel
(*Sciurus vulgaris*)
Body length: up to 10 in (25 cm)
Tail: up to 8 in (20 cm)

West European hedgehog
(*Erinaceus europaeus*)
Length: up to 9.6 in (24.5 cm)

Prickly armor

A hedgehog has 7,000 spines or more on its back. Spines are really modified hairs. Although they are hollow, they are very strong and have sharp points. When a hedgehog is alarmed, it rolls into a ball to protect its underparts with its spines. Baby hedgehogs have soft spines so they do not scratch their mothers while suckling.

Clinging claws

The great spotted woodpecker has curved claws that help it cling to tree bark, and stiff tail feathers to support its weight against the trunk. It uses its long tongue to reach insects in trees' cracks and crevices.

Great spotted woodpecker
(*Dendrocopos major*)
Length: up to 9.5 in (24 cm)

Tawny owl (*Strix aluco*)
Length: up to 1 ft 3 in (39 cm)
Wingspan: up to 3 ft 4 in (1 m)

Silent wings

The tawny owl hunts at night. It has soft, fringed wing feathers that are specially suited for silent flying. It can see well in the dark and has very good hearing. Its prey are small creatures, such as mice and voles, which it seizes with its curved talons.

Hazel dormouse
(*Muscardinus avellanarius*)
Body length: up to 3.5 in (9 cm)
Tail: up to 3.4 in (8.6 cm)

Red fox (*Vulpes vulpes*)
Height at shoulder: up to 17.5 in (45 cm)
Body length: up to 3 ft (90 cm)

Night hunter

Red foxes hunt mainly at night. They eat almost anything, from rabbits and earthworms to fish and apples. Although their natural habitat is woodland, many foxes have now adapted to live in towns. They often come out at night to search in people's trash bins for food.

Slim hunter

The weasel has a long, thin body, which it squeezes into the burrows of mice and voles to stop them escaping. The weasel is strong for its size and can kill larger animals, such as rabbits.

Least weasel (*Mustela nivalis*)
Body length: up to 10 in (26 cm)
Tail: up to 3.5 in (9 cm)

Winter sleeper

The dormouse hibernates through the cold winter months in a warm nest of leaves and grass, usually under leaf litter or in a hollow tree stump. The dormouse prepares for hibernation by eating as much as possible in the fall and may nearly double in weight.

There are many gaps in the trees that let light down to the woodland floor.

Rotting leaves litter the woodland floor and provide a rich source of food for plants and insects.

KILOMETERS
0 100 200 300
MILES
0 100 200

T H
A

